

By 1925, when the Kelly Act was passed authorizing the Post Office to contract out mail services to private companies, mail was regularly being flown from coast to coast in about 30 hours, compared to three days by train.

A network of airways

The network of airways that the Post Office handed over to commercial operators in 1926–27 had, by the standards of the day, an impressive safety record. Ground crews ensured that aircraft were well maintained and emergency landing fields, established at roughly 30-mile (48-km) intervals along the transcontinental route, saved the skin of many a pilot in difficulty. But it was impossible at this stage to take the danger out of flying. Pilots still had to navigate by sight and had no adequate instruments for flying in poor visibility. The use

of radio was mostly restricted to transmitting weather reports from airfield to airfield along the route. This helped pilots about to take off to decide whether and where to fly, but once they were airborne they received no further information and were still at risk of flying into fog or violent storms.

One pilot who amply demonstrated the continued riskiness of airmail flying was the young Charles Lindbergh. A former Army pilot and barnstormer, Lindbergh was flying the mail between St. Louis and Chicago – one of the first routes exploited by a private contractor. In September 1926 he found himself trapped above a dense layer of ground fog outside Chicago. Unable to land, he eventually ran out of fuel and had to jump out, relying on his parachute. Unnervingly, Lindbergh heard the engine of his abandoned airplane start up again as he floated down through the fog, a little residual fuel having found its way in to the carburetor. The aircraft



LINDY'S LUCKY ESCAPE

Charles Lindbergh poses with a farmer next to the wreckage of his DH-4B biplane on the edge of a cornfield near Ottawa, Illinois, on September 16, 1926. He had managed to parachute to safety when the aircraft had run out of fuel.

crashed about a mile from where the pilot came down. Only six weeks later, Lindbergh again parachuted to safety, this time after being caught in snow and low cloud. It was a sufficiently notable repeat to catch the attention of safety-

LIGHTED AIRWAYS

TO COMPENSATE FOR THE ABSENCE of decent navigational aids or instruments for night flying, lines of beacons were installed across the United States during the 1920s, creating lighted airways. The beacons were steel towers about 50ft (15m) tall, supporting a rotating lamp and mirror that generated a powerful beam roughly equivalent to that of a lighthouse. Set roughly 10 miles (16km) apart, pilots were never out of visual range of a beacon in clear weather. Most of the lights were electric, though acetylene gas was used in remote areas. Installing beacons in mountains, swamps, and deserts was a herculean task for engineers and construction crews, especially since it was essential to site the beacons on the highest peaks.

PORTABLE FLOODLIGHT

Half-billion-candlepower floodlights were also used to mark out the airmail routes. By 1933 there were 18,000 miles (28,800km) of lighted airways across the United States.



LOADING THE MAIL

Ground crew load mailbags into the mail compartment situated in front of the pilot's cockpit in a Western Air Express (WAE) Douglas M-2 Mailplane. The WAE started Contract Air Mail Route 4 between Los Angeles and Salt Lake City, via Las Vegas, on April 17, 1926.

